Lesson Plan: Titling Your Essay

The last day of the program. Students have written their introductions, thesis statements, body paragraphs and conclusions; today they give their essays a title as special and original as the work they've put in, add the finishing touches, and celebrate. Brian: "The title is like the cherry on top of the ice cream sundae that is a great essay."

STUDENTS WILL…

- Review what they've learned
- Understand what makes a strong title
- Write a colon title for their essay
- Clean up and format their essays, then submit

TEACHER WILL…

- Lead the course review
- Teach the colon title
- Celebrate students' work

MATERIALS NEEDED

Slide deck · Student laptops/chromebooks and access to yawp.school

Optional Opening: Course Review

1. Go through the course review: things students have seen and know. You might even make it a final quiz for an easy grade, to reward them for all of their hard work.

   SLIDES 2–14

2. The one some students still get wrong: they cling to the idea that a good conclusion restates the thesis and main ideas. It doesn't. A good conclusion should be compelling and interesting and offer some final conclusions or deductions on the topic. Show the suggested structure for anyone still working on theirs.

   SLIDE 15

The Lesson

1. We've all seen titles like "English Essay" or "My Paper." Maybe that's acceptable for students who haven't spent time on their papers, but our students have invested their time and energy to create something special and original. Their titles should be too.

   SLIDE 16

2. A title should be **informative, smart, and memorable**: it indicates the topic of the discussion in a thoughtful way. Teach the **colon title** with the three examples.

   SLIDE 17

3. Break the titles into their two halves. The **left side** is a creative or fun element; the **right side** is a clear, direct description of what the essay is about. Alone, either side is ordinary at best and confusing at worst: “Beyond the Boys Club” could be about anything. Together, the left side gives flavor to the right and makes it pop.

   `SLIDE 18`

   a. All three examples happen to start the right side with “How.” That isn’t required: it just has to describe the essay directly.

Writing Activity

1. Students draft and revise their titles. The Tutor knows the colon title and gives students the same instructions, so they can use it to draft and revise.

2. **Finishing touches.** Have students put it all together:

   `SLIDES 19–21`

   a. **Clean up:** delete pre-writing, observation and analysis notes, and headings like “Introduction.” Only the essay stays.

   b. **Title it:** title on the first line, centered and in italics, using the toolbar.

   c. **Keep it simple:** “Be normal with your formatting. This is not the place to be creative.” YAWP! sets the font; paragraphs stay left-aligned (only the title is centered), with an empty line between them. If you have your own formatting standards, use them.

   d. **Read it, then Submit:** read it once from the top, ask the Tutor for feedback if they want, then click Submit.

Celebrate

1. You and your students have been in this together, so feel good about what you’ve done. Ask students for some reflections on the process, or have them highlight their favorite part of their essay and explain why in a comment.

2. Share the work: within the class, or, once you’ve read and graded it, with other English teachers or administrators. The YAWP! Writing Program can also publish a class’s essays as a printed book for students, parents and administrators.

New. Brian Connell wrote no lesson plan for this lesson; this one is written from his Lesson 7 training video.